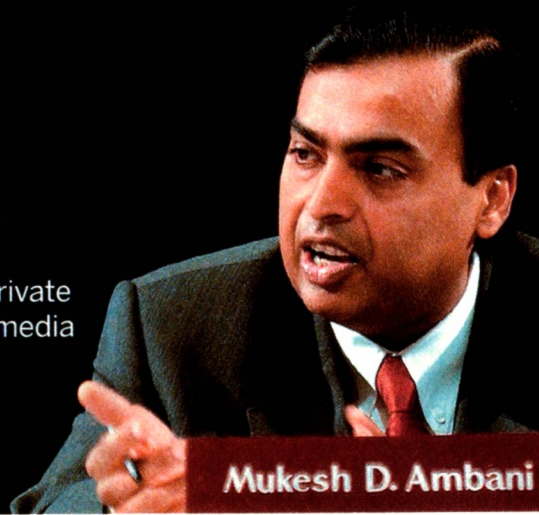




Anil D. Ambani



Mukesh D. Ambani

2004 AMBANI FEUD

Brothers at War

Mukesh kept their differences in the private domain but Anil took his cause to the media

The apocryphal story in the corporate world in the 1990s was that if you started a conversation with one brother on one line you could complete it seamlessly with the other in another time zone. They were Ram and Lakshman, or simply *bhai log*, depending on where you figured in the geo-politics of the corporate world. Sometime in the second half of 2002, after patriarch Dhirubhai Ambani died, in the Belvedere, The Chambers and on Dalal Street, they spoke of a war brewing in south Mumbai in hushed whispers. At stake was India's largest private industrial house worth Rs 1,30,000 crore which hosted among others a financial services unit, a telecom company and a Fortune 500 firm. The first visible sign of differences was Anil Ambani entering the Rajya Sabha. As the whispers grew louder, one winter evening in 2004, Mukesh Ambani shattered the suspense with one of the most widely reported quotes of the decade. "There are differences with my brother over ownership issues but they are in the private domain." This under-statement was the first clarion call. Within hours, the war between the Ambani brothers, Mukesh and Anil, was the most followed reality show across India. It would seem that the Ramayana's characters had migrated to the sets of the Mahabharata. As in the Mahabharata, the battle was replete with stories of good, evil, love, hatred, greed, sacrifice and chicanery. Mukesh, with the qualified quote placing the fight in the "private domain", played big brother while Anil, inspired by Sun Tzu and backed by a crack legal team, launched a media blitzkrieg. It is a testimony to the Ambani power that despite the high velocity charges, nobody in the government interfered or intervened in the war. The war, rather the battle, was eventually settled by mother Kokila by splitting the empire with the help of K.V. Kamath and Kalpana Morparia in June 2005. In true Ambani tradition, the deal was declared a demerger and in Dhirubhai style resulted in an unexpected rise in shareholder wealth. As in reel life, so in real life. Within two years of the settlement, the two sides were at

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war again. This time it was on the allocation of gas to the Anil-run power business as promised in the settlement. Depending on who you believe, this war is as much about a given word as it is about assets worth Rs 40,000 crore. As earlier, Anil unleashed high voltage data and details to the media. In the second innings too, the prime minister, the ministerial friends and even the courts are advising the brothers to settle. Once again they hope the mother will intervene. Will she? Stay tuned.

by Shankkar Aiyar

THE WARRING AMBANI BROTHERS

THE MAIN EVENT

Tsunami

As director of the National Disaster Management Group, Dr S.K. Swami, knows that one phone call could turn a leisurely Sunday into a nightmare. And that is exactly what happened on December 26 when the Met Office informed him about the wrath of the tsunami in India's coastal states. As the nodal officer in charge of emergency response, Swami lost no time and soon the RAX lines to the PMO, the cabinet secretary and relief commissioners were buzzing. For once, the Centre was not caught napping. *India Today*, January 10, 2005

A DEVASTATED JUNGLE GHAT JETTY AT PORT BLAIR



SUMITRA GHOSH/www.indiatodayimages.com

Top 10 Disasters

Tangshan quake

China's mining city was devastated in 1976 with 6.55 lakh people dead.

African drought

Twenty nations hit from 1981-84; 20,000 people starved to death each month.

Armenian Earthquake

Spitak was destroyed, all its residents died. Over 1 lakh died in Leninakan.

Bangladesh Floods

The 1991 floods disrupted the lives of millions, killing 1.4 lakh people.

Gujarat Earthquake

Killed 20,000 people, injured 1.67 lakh in 2001 and destroyed nearly 4 lakh homes.